

A Research Principle for the AI Era

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Research should pursue intrinsic value while first building the external support needed to sustain it.

For a sufficiently long research horizon, the model below gives a precise conclusion: even when intrinsic value is the only objective, every optimal strategy begins by allocating all resources to external value.

Intrinsic value is the scientific contribution the researcher ultimately values. External value is support convertible into research funding, measured in the same units as expenditure.

Assumptions

Consider n research cycles, starting with a seed budget $c_1 = 1$. In cycle i , expenditure is c_i and the fraction allocated to intrinsic work is $p_i \in [0, 1]$.

1. Linear returns. Intrinsic value, external value, and the next budget satisfy

$$I_i = a_i p_i c_i, \quad E_i = b_i (1 - p_i) c_i, \quad c_{i+1} = d_i E_i.$$

The vectors (a_i, b_i, d_i) are iid across cycles. All coefficients are bounded above, and a_i has a positive lower bound. Write

$$b = \text{ess inf } b_i, \quad d_i \geq 1 \text{ almost surely.}$$

External support is fully carried into the next research budget.

2. A growing reserve. The funding balance obeys

$$B_0 = 0, \quad B_i = B_{i-1} + E_i - c_i,$$

with the requirement

$$B_i \geq \rho B_{i-1} \text{ almost surely,} \quad 1 < \rho < b.$$

Research income must cover spending while growing the reserve.

3. Intrinsic value as the sole objective. The researcher observes the current budget and balance and chooses p_i before the current coefficients are drawn. Coefficient realizations are not directly revealed. Only b , $\mathbb{E}[b_i]$, and $\mathbb{E}[b_i d_i]$ are known about the common distribution. The objective is

$$\max \mathbb{E} \left[\sum_{i=1}^n I_i \right].$$

The result

Theorem 1. *There is a finite integer $K \geq 1$, independent of the horizon n , such that whenever $n > K$, every optimal strategy allocates all resources to external value in the first $n - K$ cycles:*

$$p_i = 0 \quad (1 \leq i \leq n - K), \quad \text{almost surely.}$$

A numerical example

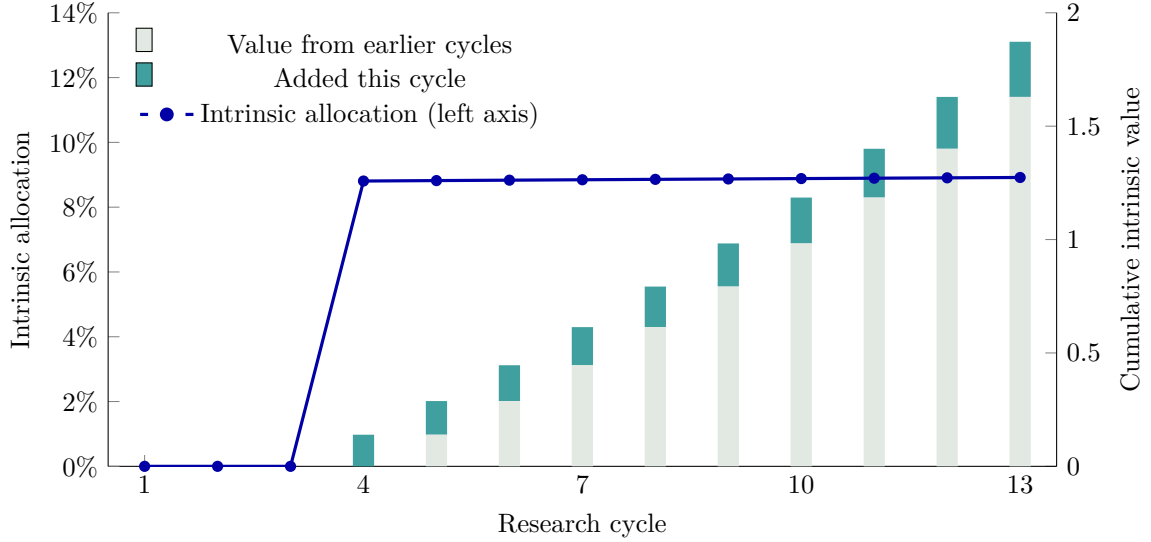


Figure 1: An optimal allocation: the first three cycles produce no intrinsic value because all resources go to external work. The line shows the intrinsic allocation share. Each bar shows cumulative intrinsic value, with the current increment highlighted.

Take $n = 13$, $a_i = 1$, $b_i = 1.11$, and $d_i = \rho = 1.05$ in every cycle. Here $K = 10$: maximizing total intrinsic value begins with three cycles devoted entirely to external value.

Proof

Every feasible state satisfies $0 \leq B \leq c$: this holds initially and is preserved because

$$0 \leq B' = B + E - c \leq E \leq d_i E = c'.$$

Write $u = (1 - p)c$ for external expenditure. The reserve constraint gives the feasible interval

$$\frac{c + (\rho - 1)B}{b} \leq u \leq c.$$

Independence lets us divide the objective by the positive constant $\mathbb{E}[a_i]$, giving stage reward $c - u$. Set

$$w = \mathbb{E}[b_i], \quad v = \mathbb{E}[b_i d_i], \quad v \geq w \geq b > \rho > 1.$$

The value function with m cycles remaining is linear: $V_m(c, B) = A_m c + D_m B$, with $A_0 = D_0 = 0$. To see this, define $S_m = vA_m + wD_m$. The Bellman objective is

$$(1 - D_{m-1})c + D_{m-1}B + (S_{m-1} - 1)u.$$

Its maximizing endpoint depends only on S_{m-1} , and both endpoints are linear in (c, B) , completing the induction.

When $S_{m-1} \leq 1$, choose the lower endpoint. Starting from $S_0 = D_0 = 0$, this gives

$$D_m = D_{m-1} + \frac{(\rho - 1)(S_{m-1} - 1)}{b} \leq 0$$

and

$$\begin{aligned} S_m &= \frac{v + w(\rho - 1)}{b} S_{m-1} + \frac{v(b - 1) - w(\rho - 1)}{b} \\ &\quad + (w - v)D_{m-1} \geq \rho S_{m-1} + b - \rho. \end{aligned}$$

Since $\rho > 1$ and $b > \rho$, this sequence crosses 1 in finite time. Let $K = \min\{m \geq 1 : S_m > 1\}$.

Once $S_{m-1} > 1$, the unique maximizing choice is $u = c$. Then $D_m = D_{m-1} \leq 0$ and

$$S_m = vS_{m-1} + (w - v)D_{m-1} > S_{m-1} > 1.$$

Thus every decision with more than K cycles remaining uniquely allocates everything to external value. These are precisely the first $n - K$ cycles. $\square$

Even when only intrinsic value matters, the optimal starting allocation is entirely external.